

Episode 138: Once Upon a Time... 82 – 1995 Part 2 – Pseudo-Digital? February

"Heat and cold until the equinox"

...How well the ancients said that! The Japanese archipelago truly became "autumn" all at once with this equinox as the border. Typhoons came properly too. I finally put on long sleeves! Ah, I'd planned to stay in short sleeves until October this year (wry laugh).

Ultra!! Mecha-Mote Chairman that I'm participating in has background art entering "autumn mode" from around what we're making now. Inwardly I was thinking "What if it stays hot forever? (sweat)" but wow, quite relieved. Mood-wise for us makers, we can finally enter "autumn mode."

Now then.

Dragon Ball Z Movie: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta for March release got through editing and dubbing mostly with original photography, finally entering full-scale crunch mode in February.

"I want to show Janemba's instant transmission digital-like," said Director Yamauchi. "Eh? Digital-like? (sweat)" said Animation Director Yamamuro and me.

Actually from around this time, personal computers were starting to enter the graphics world. While not yet concretely entering anime production, at individual levels PCs were gradually becoming objects of interest.

"Apple Computer's Macintosh..." said Director Yamauchi. Within Oizumi Studio, Director Yamauchi was actually at the centre of that PC mood, Mac mood. People around the director gradually got "brainwashed" and "influenced" by PC and Mac moods. Including me (laugh).

So, about Janemba.

Naturally not using CG, but strictly an order to make it "digital-like" with animation. What this meant was basically making Janemba's instant transmission "disappearance" and "appearance" afterimages in mosaic-style animation for "pseudo-digital-ish" imagery. I see, the mood is digital-ish (laugh). Plus we were asked to devise colours so mosaic part cross-sections would deliberately look flickery.

This was quite difficult. Painting each mosaic piece's cross-section differently, painting each cel so they wouldn't be continuous. This was hard to achieve.

Painting work normally requires attention to proper continuous colour application—avoiding so-called "colour flicker"—but even noting on key animation and in-between animation to "make it look flickery," it rarely painted up as intended. Everyone still painted properly after all.

Ultimately, most "instant transmission cuts" got retake processing during finishing inspection. We repainted cel fronts one by one to look flickery.

Checking those cuts on rushes film: "...Hmm (wry laugh)" from everyone (laugh). But it probably became interesting screens anyway.

Always giving somewhat surprising orders like that, Director Yamauchi's screen creation added various techniques during shoot preparation. This time too we shot adding various materials during shoot preparation.

For example, high-contrast screens. Photocopying background art in black and white. Making high-contrast black-white inverted copies with various adjustments. Using those copies as master plates for lithograph mask machines to create transmitted light masks. Laying those masks on backgrounds for photography to add light effects for even stranger high-contrast screens.

Using copy machines like that could be considered digital in a way? Hm? Not really?
(laugh)

Getting through fun, difficult crunch like that, somehow reaching completion by late February. Then nationwide release first week of March. Incidentally, simultaneous screenings were *SLAM DUNK* and *Marmalade Boy*.

The story climax has "Gogeta," who appears through Goku and Vegeta's fusion technique, magnificently defeating Janemba and restoring order between this world and the next. As a result, Vegeta, who was revived by Janemba, becomes soul-only again. I quite liked this part—Vegeta's cool departure got me a bit emotional.

(10.09.28)